

SALEM ARCANA

Master Game Guide & iOS Beta Engineer Handoff

V9 FULL ENGINEER QC REBUILD - COMPLETE CANON PACKAGE

Rebuilt after V8 was identified as a condensed QC document. V9 restores the full handoff structure while preserving the latest final rules.

Latest canon corrections included: unlimited card plays within Witchfire budget, 1-card draw until Patient, 2-card draw after Patient, Patience countdown only when zero cards are played, Witchfire carryover only after Patient, Ritual Wheel combat, Seal Influence scoring, layered UI implementation, compact HUD Ritual Wheel badge.

0. V9 Completeness Notice

Answer to the QC concern: V8 was shorter because it was a condensed clean-QC rebuild. It was useful as a rules summary, but it was not the full engineer handoff package. V9 restores the comprehensive content expected for engineering handoff: rules, UI locks, layering instructions, runtime data contracts, pseudocode, tutorial, AI guidance, hook economy, deck systems, dev tickets, AGENTS.md, QA, and lore/season context.

Artifact	Purpose	Use for engineering?
V5	Large handoff with UI layering and wheel instructions, but predates the final Witchfire/draw/Patience corrections.	Reference only; superseded when rules conflict.
V8	Condensed final-QC rules rebuild.	Too short as a full handoff.
V9	Full engineer handoff rebuilt with all latest canon rules and full implementation detail.	Use this as the primary handoff.

1. Canon Locks - Final Engineer Source of Truth

When this document conflicts with earlier PDFs, chat notes, images, or prototype assumptions, this V9 document wins unless the conflict is strictly visual and the locked UI image is more specific. Blue text marks the most recent canon rules confirmed during final QC.

Area	Locked Rule	Engineering Meaning
Card play	Players may play as many cards as their available Witchfire can afford.	Remove every deprecated single-card play cap. Turn ends when player taps end turn, passes, or has no desired/legal plays.
Draw cadence	Draw 1 card per turn before Patient; draw 2 cards per turn after Patient.	Do not grant extra draws before Patient except scripted tutorial/debug tools.
Witchfire curve	Round 1=2, Round 2=3, Round 3=4, Round 4=5, Round 5=6, Round 6=7, OT=7.	Use this exact curve for both player and AI.
Witchfire carryover	Unused Witchfire is lost before Patient. After Patient, unused Witchfire carries over and stacks until spent.	Carryover requires isPatient == true.
Patience trigger	Patience countdown decreases only if the player played zero cards that turn.	Ending a turn after playing 1+ cards never decreases Patience.
Patience UI	Countdown starts at 3 in purple. At 0, notify player and turn countdown yellow.	HUD must visually distinguish not-Patient vs Patient.
Score	Seal Influence is the official win score and appears in the Ritual Power counter.	Ritual Power counter is not a separate resource in battle; it displays live score.
Combat resolution	End-of-turn combat resolves through the Ritual Wheel, lane by lane, sequentially.	No simultaneous full-board trigger dump.
Hooks	Hooks are not granted as free starter hooks. They drop from packs/boss rewards or unlock with upgrade currency.	Starter deck contains hook-eligible cards but not guaranteed active hooks.
UI	Locked supplied UI images are visual source of truth. All dynamic UI must be layered.	Do not implement flat screenshots as final runtime screens.

2. Full Core Match Rules

2.1 Match Structure

- Regular match: 6 rounds, followed by optional one-round overtime if the final regular Seal Influence scores are within 5% of each other.
- Overtime: one OT round only. Final Seal Influence after OT is final even if scores remain within 5%.
- Turn ownership: both player and opponent follow the same Witchfire curve, draw rules, patience trigger, card play budget, and Ritual Wheel resolution.
- Turn action: a player may play any number of cards while available Witchfire can pay costs and legal slots/targets exist.
- Pass/no-card turn: choosing to end a turn with zero cards played counts as a no-card turn and can reduce the Patience countdown.

2.2 Witchfire / Energy

Witchfire is the match resource used to pay card costs. It refreshes at the start of each round based on the fixed curve. Before Patient, unused Witchfire disappears at end of turn. After Patient, unused Witchfire banks and stacks until spent.

Round	Base Witchfire	Carryover allowed before Patient?	Carryover allowed after Patient?
1	2	No	Yes, if Patient has already been achieved by an earlier condition or debug/tutorial state.
2	3	No	Yes
3	4	No	Yes
4	5	No	Yes
5	6	No	Yes
6	7	No	Yes
OT	7	No	Yes

2.3 Patience

Patience is a comeback/planning state earned by skipping card plays over time. The countdown is not a pass button cooldown and not a generic end-turn counter. It only advances when the player ends a turn after playing zero cards.

Situation	Does Patience countdown decrease?	Reason
Player plays 0 cards and ends turn	Yes, -1	This is a true no-card turn.
Player plays 1 card and ends turn	No	A card was played. Patience does not advance.
Player plays 2+ cards and ends turn	No	A card was played. Patience does not advance.
Player cannot afford any card but still has cards in hand	Yes if they end with 0 cards played	The trigger checks cardsPlayedThisTurn == 0.
Player has no cards in hand	Yes if they end with 0 cards played	Still a no-card turn.

Patient benefits: draw 2 cards at turn start instead of 1, unused Witchfire carries over and stacks, and UI changes countdown/Patient indicator from purple to yellow with a notification: "You are Patient."

2.4 Turn State Pseudocode

```
struct TurnState {
    var round: Int
```

```

    var baseWitchfire: Int
    var bankedWitchfire: Int
    var availableWitchfire: Int
    var cardsPlayedThisTurn: Int
    var patienceCountdown: Int // starts at 3
    var isPatient: Bool
}

func startTurn(_ state: inout TurnState, player: inout PlayerState) {
    state.baseWitchfire = witchfireForRound(state.round) // 2,3,4,5,6,7,7
    state.cardsPlayedThisTurn = 0
    state.availableWitchfire = state.baseWitchfire + (state.isPatient ? state.bankedWitchfire : 0)
    let drawCount = state.isPatient ? 2 : 1
    player.drawCards(drawCount)
}

func playCard(_ card: CardInstance, state: inout TurnState) throws {
    guard card.cost <= state.availableWitchfire else { throw PlayError.notEnoughWitchfire }
    guard board.hasLegalPlacement(card) else { throw PlayError.noLegalPlacement }
    state.availableWitchfire -= card.cost
    state.cardsPlayedThisTurn += 1
    board.place(card)
}

func endTurn(_ state: inout TurnState) {
    if state.cardsPlayedThisTurn == 0 && !state.isPatient {
        state.patienceCountdown = max(0, state.patienceCountdown - 1)
        if state.patienceCountdown == 0 { state.isPatient = true }
    }
    state.bankedWitchfire = state.isPatient ? state.availableWitchfire : 0
}

```

3. Seal Influence - Official Scoring and Win Condition

Seal Influence is the only match-winning score. The game board UI currently labeled Ritual Power must display live Seal Influence. This keeps the locked UI composition while changing the runtime meaning of the counter.

3.1 Scoring Components - Tutorial Order

The tutorial must teach score in descending order of influence. Use this exact order so players understand what matters most.

Order	Score Factor	Meaning	Typical Impact
1 - Most influential	Lane Control	Winning lane/point control grants the largest fixed score chunks.	+250 per controlled standard lane; +350 for center/awakened lane when active.
2	Surviving Board Value	Surviving Health + Ward + current Power remains valuable at match end.	Adds all surviving value.
3	Ritual Pressure	Damage dealt becomes score pressure, rewarding aggressive turns.	Total damage dealt x 0.25.
4 - Least influential but dramatic	Witness Marks	Story/action achievements grant bonus score.	Usually +25 to +180, higher for major awakenings.

3.2 Final Score Formula

```
LaneScore(lane, player) = sum(card.remainingHealth + card.remainingWard + card.currentPower)
LaneControlBonus = 250 per standard controlled lane + 350 for center/awakened controlled lane
SurvivingBoardValue = sum(all surviving health + ward + power)
RitualPressure = floor(totalDamageDealt * 0.25)
WitnessMarks = sum(triggeredWitnessMarkValues)
SealInfluence = LaneControlBonus + SurvivingBoardValue + RitualPressure + WitnessMarks
```

3.3 Overtime Rule

At the end of Round 6, compare Seal Influence totals. If the scores are within 5% of each other, play one OT round using 7 Witchfire. Final Seal Influence after OT decides the winner. There is no second OT.

```
let high = max(playerSealInfluence, opponentSealInfluence)
let margin = abs(playerSealInfluence - opponentSealInfluence) / max(high, 1)
if margin <= 0.05 { enterOneOvertimeRound() } else { highestSealInfluenceWins() }
```

3.4 Witness Mark Examples

Witness Mark	Trigger	Suggested Score
First Awakening	First player in match awakens a Tier 3.	+150
Destroy Tier 3	Destroy or banish a Tier 3 card.	+180
Survive by Barrier	Barrier prevents lethal or high damage.	+50
Become Patient	Patience reaches 0 for first time.	+50
Chain on 3 Targets	Chain effect hits 3 targets in one resolution.	+75
Comeback Lane	Take a lane while behind in Seal Influence.	+75

4. Ritual Wheel Combat Resolution

End-of-turn combat resolves through the Ritual Wheel. The wheel is a gameplay rule, an animation system, and a UI object. It prevents the board from firing all card effects at once.

4.1 Lane Order

Turn	Lane Resolution Order
1	Top -> Left -> Right -> Awakened/Center
2	Left -> Right -> Top -> Awakened/Center
3	Right -> Top -> Left -> Awakened/Center
4	Top -> Left -> Right -> Awakened/Center
5	Left -> Right -> Top -> Awakened/Center
6	Right -> Top -> Left -> Awakened/Center
OT	Wheel continues from previous turn index or uses final highlighted OT order.

4.2 Per-Lane Phase Order

Phase	Name	What resolves
1	Defense Setup	Guard, Ward, Barrier, protection redirection, legal target refresh.
2	Buff / Debuff	Power buffs, Vulnerable, Marked, Cleanse, family damage bonus application flags.
3	Damage	Primary attacks and direct damage effects.
4	Special Effects	Chain, Cleave, Drain, Sacrifice, Echo, Hook, Awakening-related effects.
5	Death Cleanup	Destroyed cards leave after current queued action, then death rewards/marks resolve.
6	Status Tick	Burn, curse, temporary modifiers, duration cleanup.
7	Seal Influence Update	Ritual Power counter updates after the lane/stack resolves.

4.3 Card Order Within a Lane

- On Reveal: newest card first, because the newly played card is the dramatic focal point of the turn.
- Persistent effects: oldest card first, because board setup should matter.
- Awakened/Tier 3 effects: resolve last within the lane unless card text explicitly overrides.
- Death cleanup: destroyed cards remain visually present until the current action finishes, then exit cleanly.
- Action queue: every effect creates a CombatAction with source, target, value, text label, VFX key, and score delta.

4.4 CombatAction Data Contract

```
struct CombatAction: Codable, Identifiable {
    let id: UUID
    let phase: RitualPhase
    let sourceCardInstanceID: UUID?
    let targetCardInstanceID: UUID?
    let targetLane: LaneID?
    let effectType: EffectType
    let amount: Int
    let impactLabel: String
    let vfxKey: String
```

```
    let sealInfluenceDelta: Int  
}
```

5. Targeting System - Hybrid Ritual Targeting

Salem Arcana uses fast lane-first targeting with selective focus targeting. Most cards resolve automatically based on board state; some cards request a player-tapped Focus Target.

Priority	Targeting Rule	Example
1	Guarded target	If enemy Guard is active in lane, hit Guard first.
2	Marked target	Marked enemy is prioritized by targeted/random hostile hits.
3	Mirrored slot	Attack the card directly opposite if present.
4	Weakest enemy in lane	Default damage target when mirrored slot is empty.
5	Strongest enemy in lane	Used by cards that hunt threats.
6	Random enemy in lane	Used by chaotic effects. Must use deterministic seeded RNG.
7	Adjacent lane spillover	Chain/Cleave may jump to adjacent lane if text allows.

6. Cards, Stats, Keywords, and Impact Numbers

6.1 Final Larger Stat Scale

Tier	Health	Damage	Ward / Shield
Tier 1	45-80	15-32	15-35
Tier 2	90-145	35-65	35-75
Tier 3	180-260	70-115	80-140
Awakened	300-420	130-220	150-260

6.2 Keywords

Keyword	Effect	Primary Families
Guard	Enemy attacks must hit this card first in its lane.	Oathbound, Church
Ward	Shield value that absorbs damage before Health.	Oathbound, Church, Spellbook
Barrier	Blocks the next damage instance completely.	Church, Oathbound
Marked	Next targeted/random enemy hit prioritizes this card.	Salem Folk, Spellbook
Vulnerable	Takes +25% damage from next hit.	Dark Magic, Salem Folk
Burn	Takes damage at end of turn/status tick.	Elemental, Dark Magic
Chain	Damage jumps to another enemy in same or adjacent lane.	Elemental
Cleave	Hits primary target and adjacent slot targets.	Elemental, Oathbound
Drain	Deals damage and heals source.	Dark Magic
Cleanse	Removes Burn, Vulnerable, Marked, Curse.	Church
Echo	Repeats a weaker version of an On Reveal effect.	Spellbook
Sacrifice	Damages/destroys ally for larger payoff.	Dark Magic

6.3 Impact Number Rules

Event	Display Example
Damage	-72
Ward gain	+95 WARD
Healing	+48 RESTORE
Buff	+25 POWER
Debuff	-30 CURSE
Chain hit	CHAIN -42
Awakening hit	AWAKENED -188
Sacrifice payoff	BLOOD PACT +120

7. Decks, Starter Deck, Hooks, and Family Rituals

7.1 Deck Rules

- Deck size is exactly 20 cards.
- The player can save multiple decks and choose one active deck.
- A legal deck can contain exactly 1 Tier 3 anchor for the current beta rules.
- Starter deck contains 1 chosen Tier 3, 6 Tier 2 cards, and 13 Tier 1 cards.
- Starter deck must be mixed-family enough to teach the game and include examples of damage, Ward/Guard, heal/cleanse, buff/debuff, and lane effects.
- Starter deck does not guarantee active hooks. Hook cards may be hook-eligible, but hook activation is earned later.

7.2 Starter Deck Composition

Card Group	Count	Notes
Chosen Tier 3 Anchor	1	Player chooses 1 of 4 Season 1 anchors.
Tier 2 Cards	6	Mixed families; should support basic tutorial coverage.
Tier 1 Cards	13	Mixed families; should include defense, damage, support, and lane examples.
Active Hooks	0 guaranteed	Hooks drop/unlock later; no free starter hooks.
Total	20	Must validate before match start.

7.3 Hook Economy

Hooks are passive upgrade flags that allow a hook-eligible card to contribute to a Tier 3 awakening recipe. All hook cards have a random chance of dropping with the hook already active, but the chance is relatively low. A player may also unlock the hook using upgrade currency.

Card Tier	Hook Strength	Drop Chance with Active Hook	Upgrade Currency Cost
Tier 1	Standard	6%	300 Coven Ash
Tier 1	Strong	3%	375 Coven Ash
Tier 1	Signature	1.5%	450 Coven Ash
Tier 2	Standard	3%	800 Coven Ash
Tier 2	Strong	1.5%	1000 Coven Ash
Tier 2	Signature	0.75%	1200 Coven Ash

7.4 Family Ritual Bonus Tiers

Tier Name	Requirement	Bonus
Ritual Apprentice	>60% cards from one family and deck includes that family awakening card.	+10% damage on turns 3 and 5.
Ritual Summoner	>85% cards from one family and deck includes that family awakening card.	+10% damage on turns 3-6 and OT.

Tier Name	Requirement	Bonus
Ritual Master	100% cards from one family and deck includes that family awakening card.	Damage bonus plus 15% chance awakened card starts in hand. If not, 50% chance to draw awakened card in first 5 turns.

8. Tutorial - Required First-Time Match Onboarding

The tutorial must run before the player plays their first real match. It uses a controlled random legal 20-card tutorial deck. It must teach all basic mechanics, including Witchfire, multi-card plays, draw cadence, Patience, Ritual Wheel resolution, targeting, keywords, scoring, hooks, deck identity, and overtime.

8.1 Tutorial Deck Requirements

- 20 cards total.
- Exactly 1 random Tier 3 from the four Season 1 anchors.
- 6 Tier 2 cards and 13 Tier 1 cards.
- At least 2 cards from each family.
- At least 1 Guard/Ward card, 1 direct damage card, 1 chain/AoE card, 1 heal/cleanse card, and 1 buff/debuff card.
- May include hook-eligible cards, but must teach that hooks are earned from packs/boss rewards or unlocked by currency.

8.2 Tutorial Flow

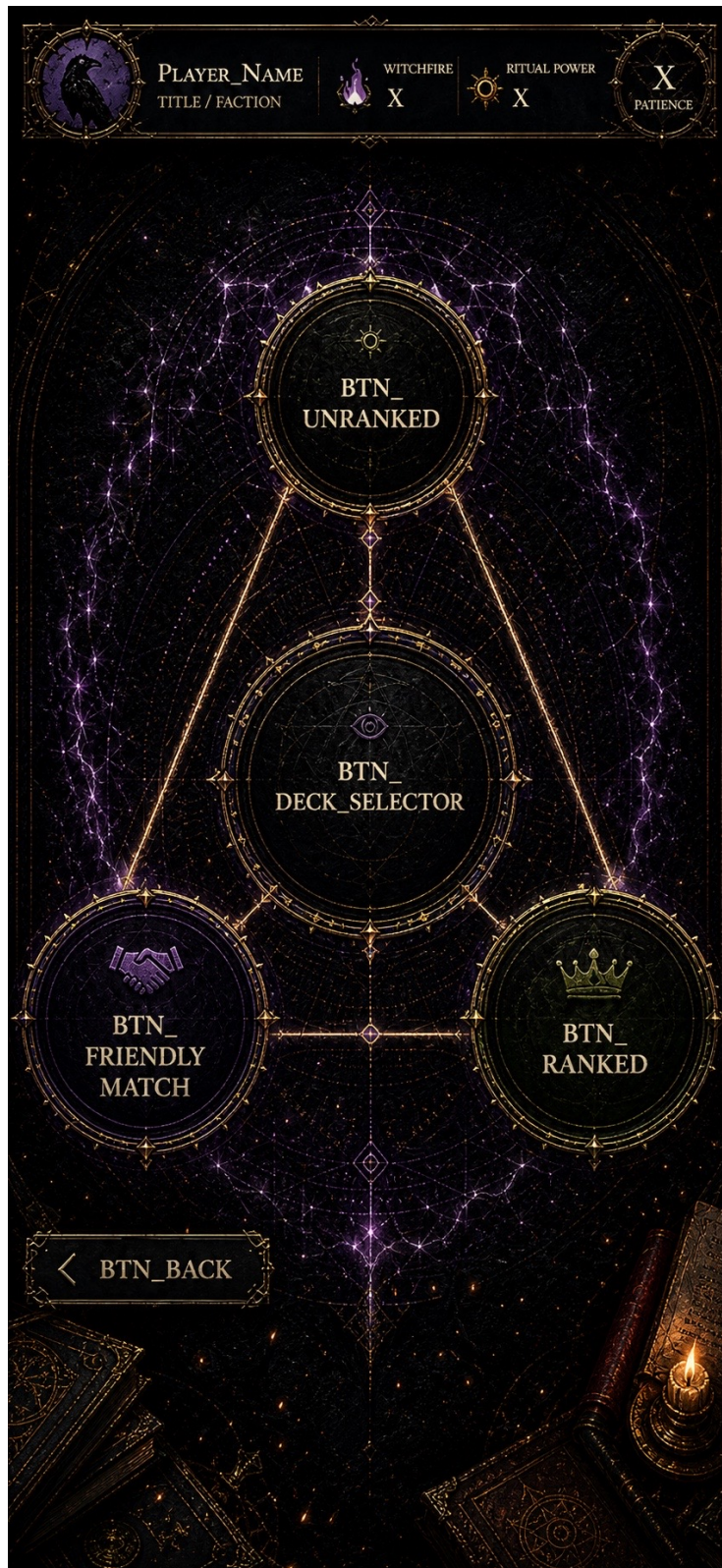
Step	Lesson	Implementation
1	Draw and hand basics	Show 1-card draw before Patient and hand layout.
2	Witchfire basics	Explain Witchfire curve and card costs.
3	Multi-card turn	Force a turn where the player plays 2 low-cost cards because Witchfire allows it.
4	Placement	Teach lanes/points and legal slots.
5	On Reveal	Play a card and show immediate effect.
6	Persistent effects	Show an end-turn effect entering the Ritual Wheel queue.
7	Guard/Ward/Barrier	Demonstrate protection before damage.
8	Buff/debuff	Apply Vulnerable or Marked, then show how it affects targeting/damage.
9	Hybrid targeting	Show mirrored target, Guard override, and Focus Target card.
10	Ritual Wheel	Show lane order and sequential resolution.
11	Scoring in order	Teach Lane Control, Surviving Board Value, Ritual Pressure, Witness Marks.
12	No-card turn	Player intentionally plays zero cards and ends turn; Patience countdown decreases.
13	Non-trigger example	Player plays at least one card and ends turn; Patience countdown does not decrease.
14	Patient unlock	After three true no-card turns, countdown hits 0, changes yellow, draw increases to 2, Witchfire carryover begins.
15	Hooks and awakening	Explain hook economy and then script a tutorial-only awakening setup.
16	Overtime	Explain within-5% OT rule if scores are close.

9. Locked UI References

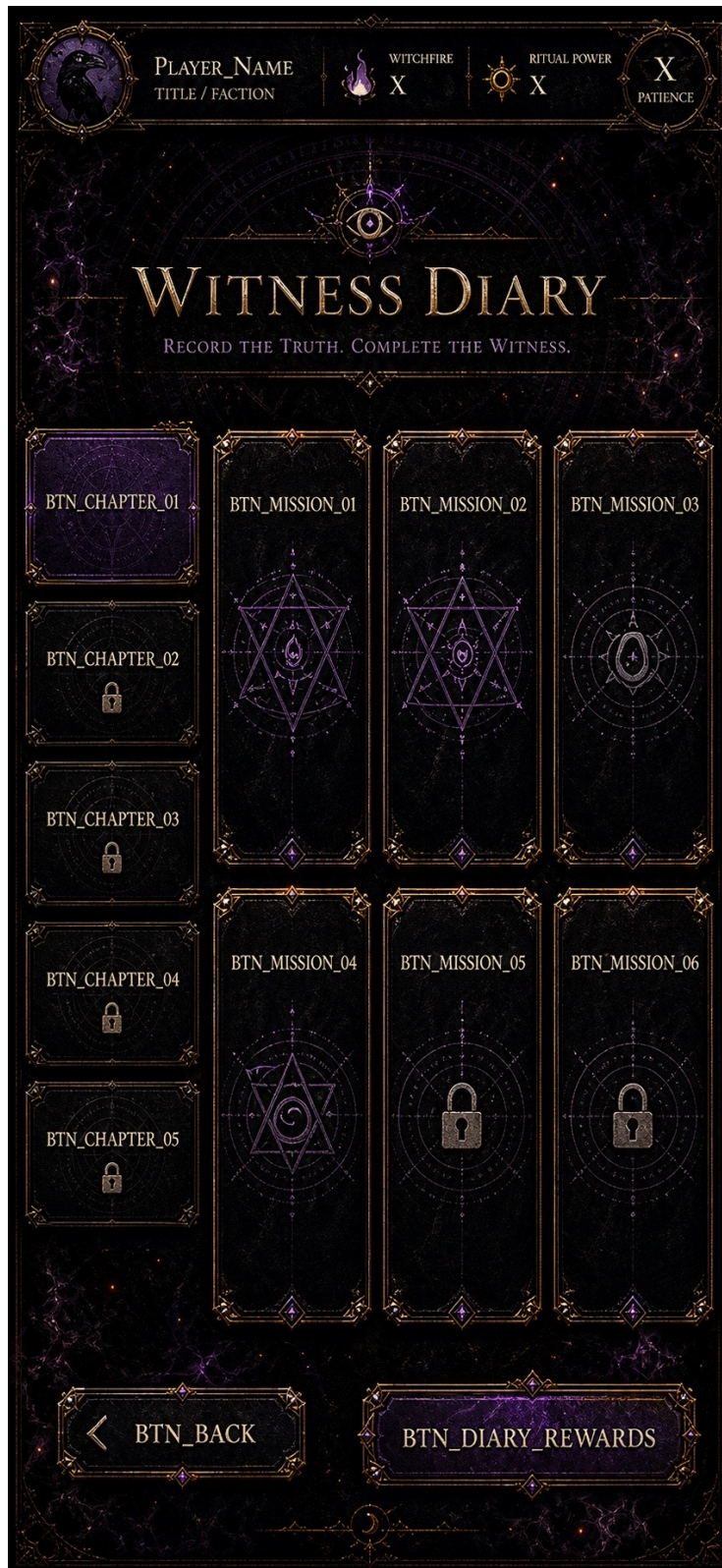
The following images are canonical visual locks. They define layout, mood, palette, typography style, frames, spacing, ornament language, and interaction pattern. They are not final flat runtime assets. Dynamic/animated elements must be split into layers and connected to state.



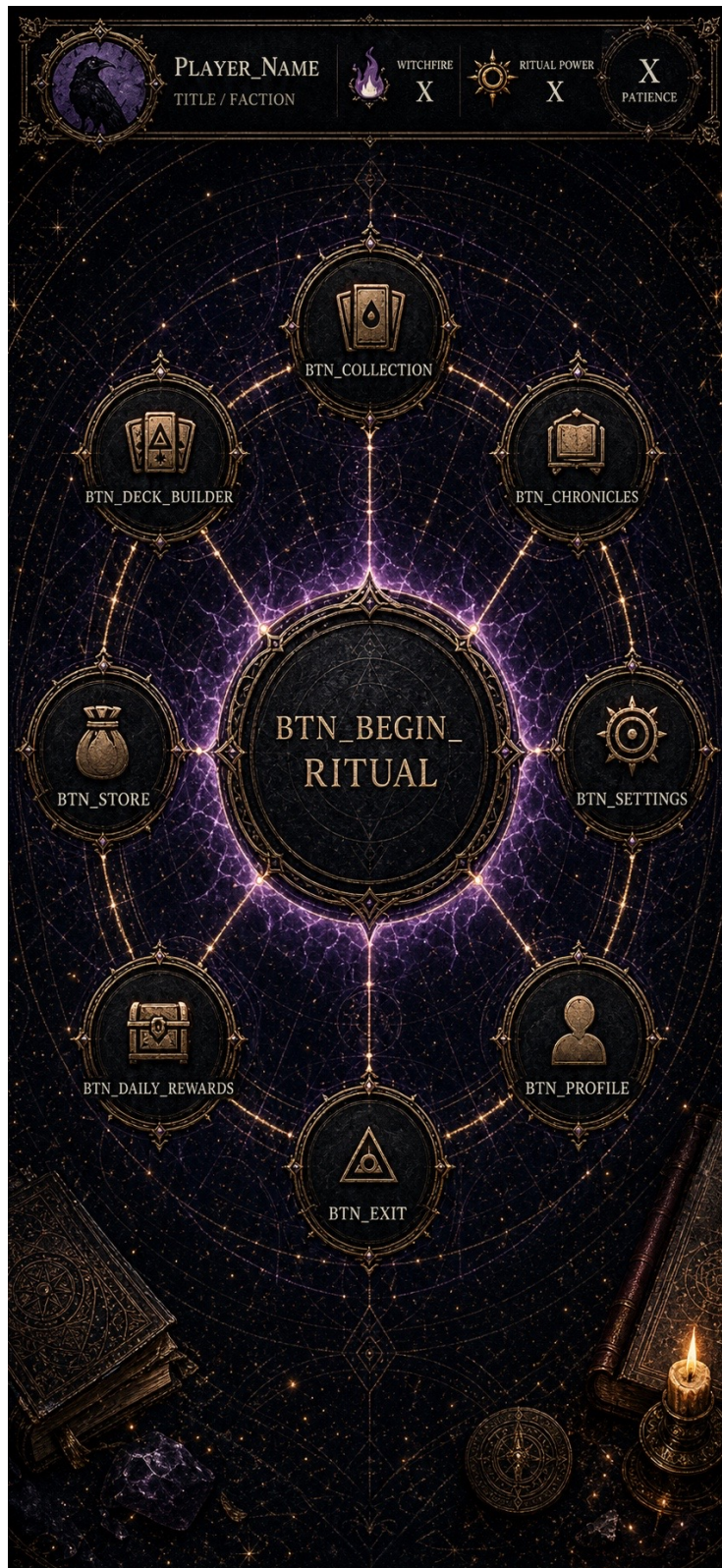
UI Lock 01 - Prefab Guide and Hierarchy



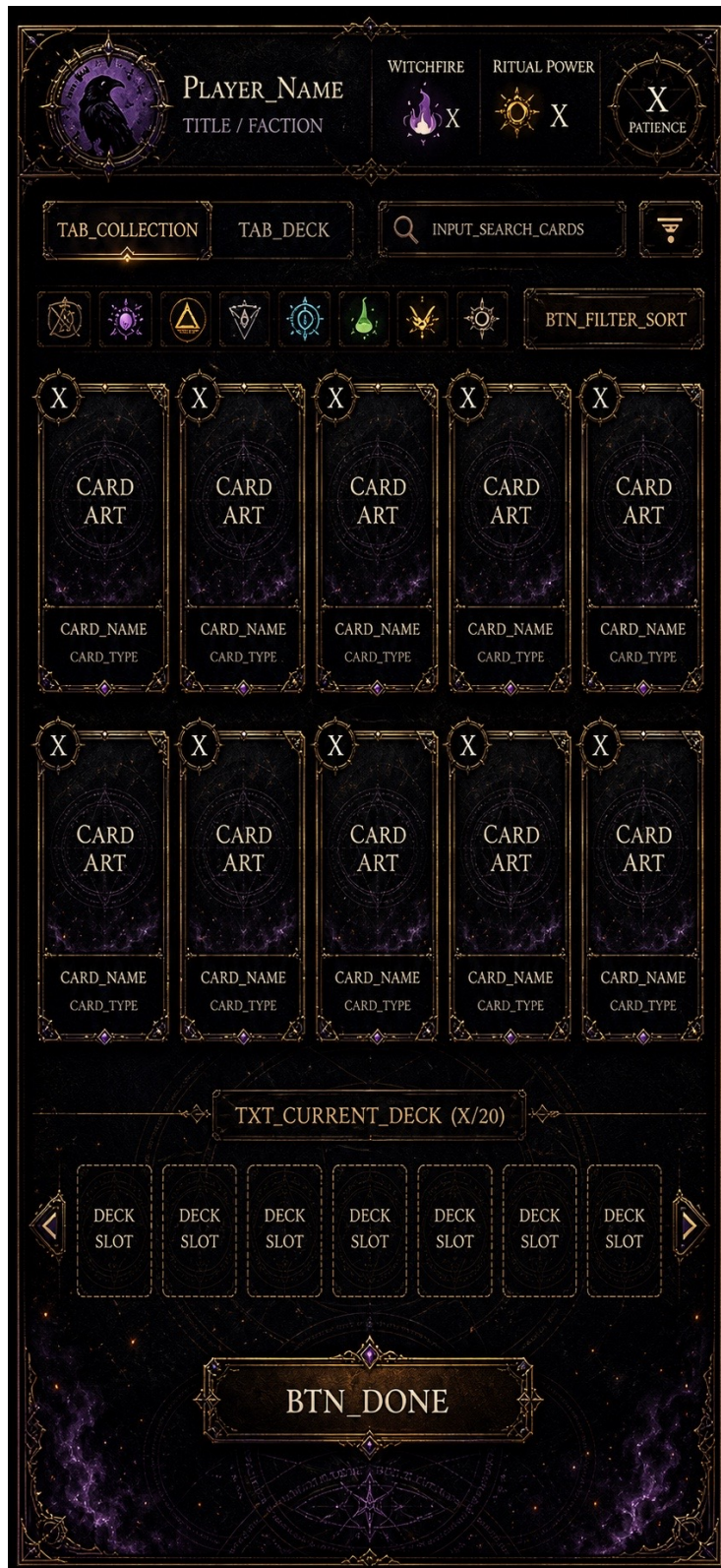
UI Lock 02 - Mode Select



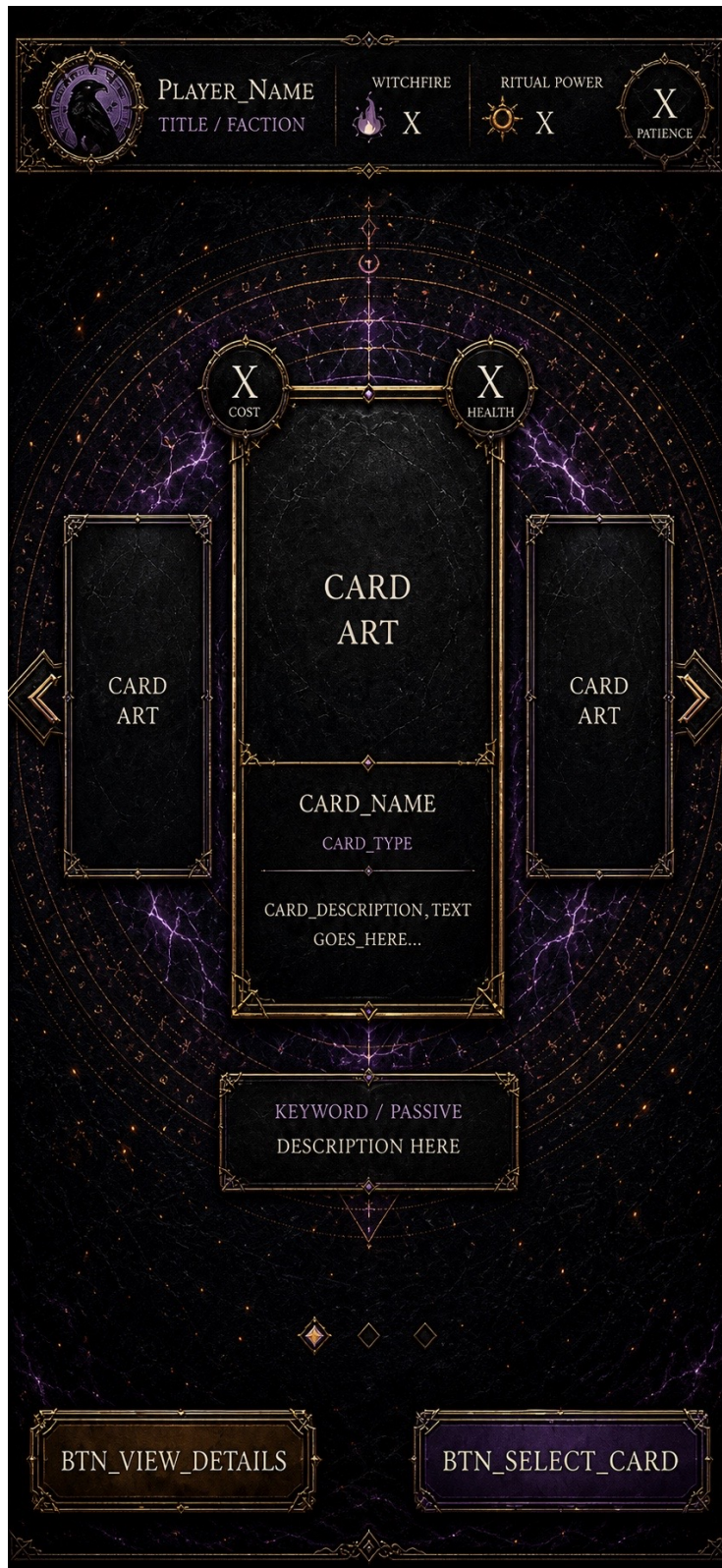
UI Lock 03 - Witness Diary



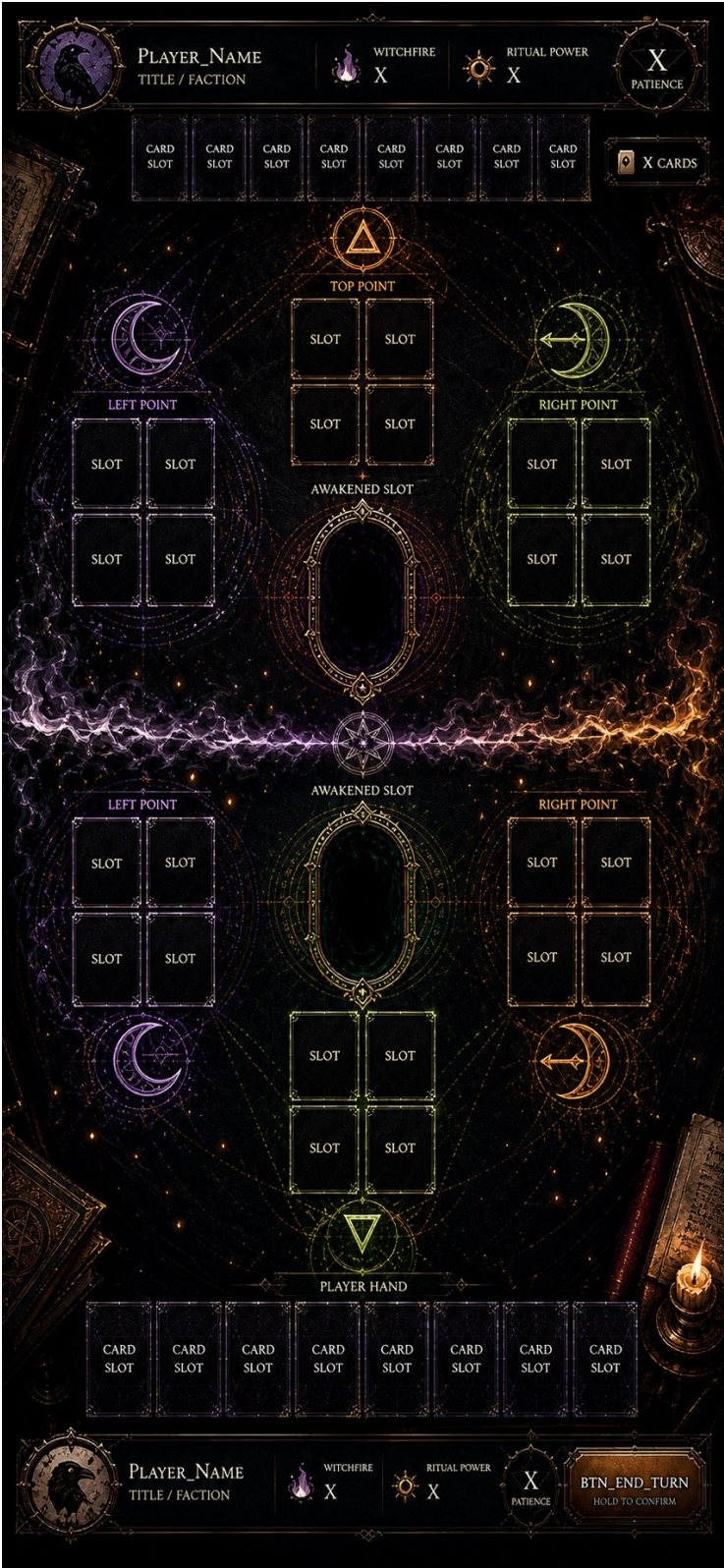
UI Lock 04 - Main Menu



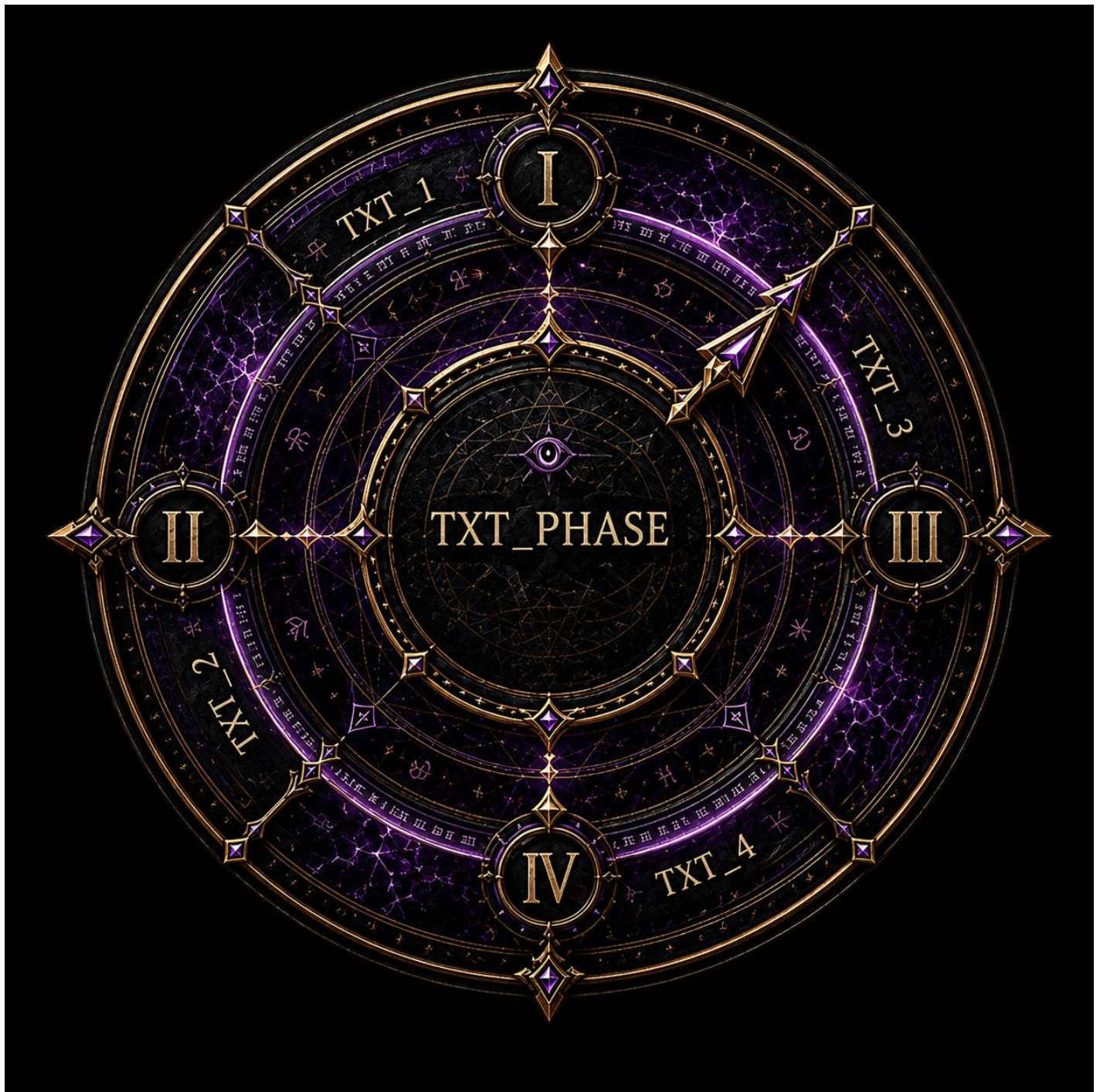
UI Lock 05 - Collection / Deck Builder



UI Lock 06 - Card Detail / Selection



UI Lock 07 - Battle Board



UI Lock 08 - Compact Ritual Wheel HUD Badge for top-left battle-board circle



UI Lock 09 - Large Ritual Wheel Design Reference

10. Universal Layered UI Production Rules

Every UI element that contains text, state, animation, selection, targeting, or input must be implemented as a layered component. Concept images define the style; the app must render live labels, values, states, glows, and moving parts.

Layer	Required For	Runtime Rule
Base Art	Static ornament/background.	Can be PNG/WebP, 9-sliced when resizable.
Frame	Buttons, cards, panels, slots.	Separate from label and icon.
Icon	Family, keyword, resource, phase markers.	Bindable image key; do not bake into frame when state can change.
Label	All text placeholders.	Render in SwiftUI/TextMesh equivalent; never rely on generated placeholder text in final art.
Value Text	Witchfire, Seal Influence, Patience, costs, health.	Bind to GameState. Must localize/scale.
Glow	Hover, active, selected, locked, warning.	Off by default; enabled by state.
Hitbox	Buttons, cards, deck slots, wheel badge.	Invisible and sized for iOS 48 pt minimum where applicable.
Animation Part	Ritual Wheel arrow, active segment, particles.	Separate asset or vector layer controlled by code.

10.1 Compact Ritual Wheel HUD Badge Instructions

The compact Ritual Wheel replaces the top-left player icon on the battle board. It must fit inside the existing circular HUD badge. It is not a flat static PNG in production.

Asset	File Name	Purpose
Base wheel	RitualWheel_Base.png	Static ornate circular wheel.
Arrow needle	RitualWheel_Arrow.png	Separate transparent rotating pointer.
Active segment	RitualWheel_ActiveSegment.png	Glowing lane/phase highlight.
Outer glow	RitualWheel_Glow.png	Pulse when phase changes.
Center text	TXT_PHASE runtime text	Rendered by app; shows active phase/lane.
Order text	TXT_1 to TXT_4 runtime text	Rendered by app if large enough; may hide at small HUD size.

```
enum RitualWheelLane: CaseIterable { case top, left, right, awakened }
enum RitualPhase { case defense, buffDebuff, damage, special, cleanup, status, scoring }
```

```
struct RitualWheelState {
    var activeLane: RitualWheelLane
    var activePhase: RitualPhase
    var turnIndex: Int
    var isResolving: Bool
}
```

```
func angle(for lane: RitualWheelLane) -> CGFloat {
    switch lane {
    case .top: return 0
    case .right: return .pi / 2
    case .awakened: return .pi
    case .left: return -.pi / 2
    }
}
```

```
arrowNode.run(SKAction.rotate(toAngle: angle(for: state.activeLane),
                             duration: 0.35,
```

```
shortestUnitArc: true))
```

11. Data Contracts and JSON Schemas

11.1 Card Definition JSON

```
{
  "id": "DM_T1_001",
  "name": "Coven Ash",
  "family": "dark_magic",
  "tier": 1,
  "cost": 2,
  "statRoll": { "healthMin": 45, "healthMax": 80, "damageMin": 15, "damageMax": 32 },
  "keywords": ["Burn", "Vulnerable"],
  "targeting": { "mode": "lane_auto", "priority": ["guard", "marked", "mirrored", "weakest"] },
  "onReveal": [{ "type": "damage", "amount": 24, "vfx": "purple_burn" }],
  "persistent": [{ "type": "burn_tick", "amount": 8, "timing": "ritual_wheel_status" }],
  "hookEligible": true,
  "hook": {
    "canDropActive": true,
    "activeDropChance": 0.06,
    "unlockCurrency": "coven_ash",
    "unlockCost": 300,
    "awakeningRecipeTags": ["ashen_covenant"]
  }
}
```

11.2 Deck Save Schema

```
{
  "deckID": "uuid",
  "name": "Dark Starter",
  "isActive": true,
  "cardInstanceIDs": ["uuid1", "uuid2"],
  "tier3AnchorID": "DM_T3_ASHEN_COVENANT",
  "familyComposition": { "dark_magic": 0.40, "elemental": 0.20, "spellbook": 0.15, "oathbound": 0.15, "salem_folk": 0.05, "church": 0.15 },
  "ritualFamilyTier": "none|apprentice|summoner|master",
  "validatedAtBuildVersion": "0.1.0"
}
```

11.3 Match State Schema

```
{
  "round": 3,
  "isOvertime": false,
  "witchfire": { "base": 4, "available": 1, "banked": 0 },
  "drawCountThisTurn": 1,
  "cardsPlayedThisTurn": 2,
  "patience": { "countdown": 3, "isPatient": false, "uiColor": "purple" },
  "sealInfluence": { "player": 920, "opponent": 870 },
  "ritualWheel": { "activeLane": "left", "activePhase": "damage", "isResolving": true }
}
```


12. Codex Implementation Guide - Step by Step

Step	Workstream	Instructions
1	Repository bootstrap	Create native iOS app target with SwiftUI shell, SpriteKit battle surface, XCTest target, fixtures, and lint/test scripts.
2	GameCore module	Implement pure Swift deterministic models: CardDefinition, CardInstance, Deck, MatchState, TurnState, RitualWheelState, SealInfluenceState.
3	Resource system	Implement Witchfire curve, multi-card play while affordable, draw 1/2 based on Patient, and carryover only after Patient.
4	Patience logic	Track cardsPlayedThisTurn. Decrement countdown only when cardsPlayedThisTurn == 0 and !isPatient. Add tests for 0, 1, and 2+ card turns.
5	Decks	Implement multiple deck saves, active deck selection, starter deck creation, validation, and family ritual tier detection.
6	Card data loader	Load JSON, validate stat ranges/keywords/targeting/hook data. Fail build/test on invalid cards.
7	Targeting resolver	Implement hybrid priority order using deterministic RNG for random targets.
8	Ritual Wheel engine	Build lane order rotation and phase queue. Generate CombatActions sequentially.
9	Scoring engine	Compute Lane Control, Surviving Board Value, Ritual Pressure, Witness Marks, and live Seal Influence.
10	UI components	Implement layered prefabs: buttons, card slots, card detail, deck slots, HUD counters, Ritual Wheel badge.
11	Battle board	Recreate locked board layout. Ritual Power counter displays Seal Influence. Top-left icon becomes Ritual Wheel badge.
12	Animations/VFX	Implement arrow rotation, active segment glow, card play, impact numbers, lane pulse, and Seal Influence count-up.
13	Tutorial	Script first-time tutorial covering all basics and scoring in most-to-least influential order.
14	AI	Implement legal play generation, Witchfire budgeting, deck role heuristics, targeting decisions, and pass/no-card strategy.
15	QA	Add XCTest coverage, snapshot checks, tutorial smoke test, deterministic replay, and physical iPhone beta validation.

13. Dev Ticket Roadmap - Empty Repo to iOS Beta

Tickets must be small enough that a single ticket is not overwhelming. Every ticket must follow the GitHub + Swift workflow: search relevant GitHub/Swift examples before implementation, implement, test, then search/check again for edge cases before closing.

Ticket	Area	Task	Acceptance
T-001	Foundation	Create repository structure	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-002	Foundation	Create Xcode project	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-003	Foundation	Add SwiftUI app shell	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-004	Foundation	Add SpriteKit battle scene placeholder	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-005	Foundation	Add XCTest target	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-006	Foundation	Add deterministic RNG utility	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-007	Foundation	Add fixture loading	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-008	Foundation	Add CI build script	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-009	Core Rules	Implement CardDefinition model	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-010	Core Rules	Implement CardInstance model	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-011	Core Rules	Implement Deck model	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-012	Core Rules	Implement MatchState model	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-013	Core Rules	Implement Witchfire curve	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-014	Core Rules	Implement multi-card play budget	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-015	Core Rules	Implement draw 1/2 cadence	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-016	Core Rules	Implement Patience countdown trigger	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.

Ticket	Area	Task	Acceptance
T-017	Core Rules	Implement Witchfire carryover after Patient	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-018	Core Rules	Implement overtime 5% rule	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-019	Cards and Decks	Create starter Tier 3 choice flow	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-020	Cards and Decks	Create starter deck generator	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.

Ticket	Area	Task	Acceptance
T-021	Cards and Decks	Implement multiple saved decks	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-022	Cards and Decks	Implement active deck selector	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-023	Cards and Decks	Implement deck validator	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-024	Cards and Decks	Implement hook economy data	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-025	Cards and Decks	Implement hook unlock currency	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-026	Cards and Decks	Implement family ritual tier detector	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-027	Cards and Decks	Implement family damage bonuses	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-028	Cards and Decks	Implement awakened draw bonus rules	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-029	Combat	Implement lane/slot board model	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-030	Combat	Implement targeting resolver	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-031	Combat	Implement Guard/Ward/Barrier	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-032	Combat	Implement buff/debuff/status models	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-033	Combat	Implement Ritual Wheel lane order	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-034	Combat	Implement Ritual Wheel phases	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-035	Combat	Implement CombatAction queue	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-036	Combat	Implement death cleanup	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-037	Combat	Implement Seal Influence scoring	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-038	Combat	Implement Witness Marks	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.

Ticket	Area	Task	Acceptance
T-039	UI	Implement universal button prefab	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-040	UI	Implement card slot prefab	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.

Ticket	Area	Task	Acceptance
T-041	UI	Implement card detail prefab	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-042	UI	Implement HUD counters	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-043	UI	Implement compact Ritual Wheel badge layers	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-044	UI	Implement arrow rotation	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-045	UI	Implement active segment glow	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-046	UI	Implement dynamic text rendering	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-047	UI	Implement deck builder screen	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-048	UI	Implement battle board layout	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-049	Tutorial and AI	Build tutorial deck fixture	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-050	Tutorial and AI	Implement tutorial step manager	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-051	Tutorial and AI	Teach Witchfire and multi-card play	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-052	Tutorial and AI	Teach Patience true no-card trigger	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-053	Tutorial and AI	Teach scoring order	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-054	Tutorial and AI	Teach Ritual Wheel combat	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-055	Tutorial and AI	Implement AI legal move list	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-056	Tutorial and AI	Implement AI scoring heuristic	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-057	Tutorial and AI	Implement AI pass strategy	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-058	Tutorial and AI	Implement deterministic replay logs	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.

Ticket	Area	Task	Acceptance
T-059	Beta	Add save migration	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-060	Beta	Add local profile	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.

Ticket	Area	Task	Acceptance
T-061	Beta	Add debug menu	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-062	Beta	Add TestFlight build settings	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-063	Beta	Run physical iPhone smoke test	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-064	Beta	Run tutorial reset test	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-065	Beta	Run deck save/load test	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-066	Beta	Run combat replay test	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-067	Beta	Run accessibility pass	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.
T-068	Beta	Final handoff review	Done when tests pass, screenshot/replay evidence is attached, and no superseded play-cap or old Patience rule remains.

14. AGENTS.md - Project Agent System

AGENTS.md - Salem Arcana

Prime Directive

Build Salem Arcana as a native iOS card battler using Swift, SwiftUI, SpriteKit, and deterministic GameCore rules. The locked UI images define visual direction. The V9 Master Handoff defines gameplay, data, tutorial, QA, and delivery rules.

Required Workflow for Every Ticket

1. Search GitHub for relevant Swift/SwiftUI/SpriteKit patterns before implementation.
2. Read the relevant section of the V9 Master Handoff.
3. Implement the smallest possible vertical slice.
4. Add or update XCTest coverage and deterministic fixtures.
5. Run the app/snapshot/replay relevant to the ticket.
6. Search/check again for edge cases or common Swift pitfalls.
7. Record evidence in the PR.

Canon Hard Stops

- Do not implement any fixed play-count cap; plays are limited by Witchfire and legal board state.
- Do not decrement Patience after any turn where one or more cards were played.
- Do not carry over Witchfire before Patient.
- Do not treat Ritual Power as a separate combat resource; it displays Seal Influence.
- Do not bake dynamic UI text into final flat images.
- Do not fire all end-of-turn card effects at once.

Agents

- Game Director Agent: protects canon and priority decisions.
- Rules Engineer Agent: owns GameCore, Witchfire, Patience, scoring, combat queue.
- UI Engineer Agent: owns layered UI components and locked screen implementation.
- Card Data Agent: owns JSON schemas, card definitions, stats, hooks, keywords.
- Tutorial Agent: owns first-time flow and mechanic explanation order.
- AI Agent: owns legal play search, heuristic scoring, and deterministic bot behavior.
- QA Agent: owns tests, replay logs, device smoke checks, and final beta gates.
- Lore/Narrative Agent: owns Witness, Jailer, factions, seasons, and tone consistency.

Final QC Checklist

Every PR must state whether it touches: Witchfire, draw, Patience, Ritual Wheel, Seal Influence, hooks, family rituals, UI layer. If yes, the PR must include a test or screenshot/replay proving the rule still matches V9.

15. QA and Final Engineer Acceptance

Test Area	Required Checks
Old rule removal	Search code/docs for any fixed play-count cap language. No active rule may limit turn play count except Witchfire, card legality, hand size, and board space.
Witchfire	Unit test R1=2, R2=3, R3=4, R4=5, R5=6, R6=7, OT=7.
Multi-card play	Player can play two or more affordable cards in one turn. Witchfire decrements correctly.
Draw cadence	Pre-Patient turn draws 1. Patient turn draws 2.
Patience trigger	0-card turn decrements. 1-card turn does not. 2-card turn does not. Countdown turns yellow at 0.
Carryover	Unused Witchfire is lost pre-Patient and banks post-Patient.
Seal Influence	Ritual Power counter displays Seal Influence and updates after Ritual Wheel phases.
Ritual Wheel	Effects resolve lane by lane and phase by phase; no full-board simultaneous dump.
Decks	Multiple decks can be saved and one active deck loaded.
Hooks	Starter deck does not grant active hooks; hooks drop/unlock only.
Tutorial	Required before first match and teaches scoring in order: Lane Control, Surviving Board Value, Ritual Pressure, Witness Marks.
Device beta	Build runs on physical iPhone, safe areas correct, touch targets usable, no clipped text.

16. Final Text Search Guardrails

Before handing to engineering, run text/code searches for superseded concepts. Any active result must be removed or rewritten.

Reject active occurrences of:

- any fixed turn play-count cap
- any rule saying turn play is limited by count instead of Witchfire
- any rule saying Patience advances after cards were played
- "Patience decreases at end turn" without the zero-card condition
- "Witchfire carries over" without the Patient condition

Required active occurrences:

- "players may play as many cards as their Witchfire allows"
- "Patience countdown decreases only when zero cards are played"
- "draw 1 before Patient; draw 2 after Patient"
- "Ritual Power counter displays Seal Influence"
- "Ritual Wheel resolves combat sequentially"

17. Lore Bible and Season Roadmap Appendix

This appendix preserves the Salem Arcana lore source so engineers, writers, card designers, and UI/UX teams have narrative context. Gameplay rules in Sections 1-16 supersede any older mechanical assumptions.

WITCHFEST DESTINY: SALEM ARCANA

Complete Game Lore — Seasons 1 through 40

THE WORLD BIBLE

The World

1692 Salem, Massachusetts. The veil between worlds is thin here—thinner than anywhere else in the colonies. Magic is real. It has always been real. But it is persecuted, driven underground by church and crown alike. The witch trials that gripped Salem were not mass hysteria. They were a cover for something deeper. Something the Puritan authorities discovered and could not explain, so they burned everyone who knew about it.

Beneath the American continent sleeps an entity of immense, geological scale. It is not evil. It is not good. It simply IS. It has slept for millennia, and the seals that keep it dormant are weakening. The first seal lies beneath Salem. When it breaks, the Witch Revolutionary War begins.

The war will cross the entire continent over forty seasons. Every river crossed, every mountain climbed, every seal broken brings the entity closer to waking. And when it wakes, the world will have to decide: is this a monster to be destroyed, or a being to be understood?

The Spark

The inciting event that ignites the war is called simply "The Spark." On a winter night in 1692, in a hidden chamber beneath the Salem meeting house, a coven of Dark Magic practitioners attempts a ritual to strengthen the seal—not break it. They believe the seal is failing and that they can reinforce it with a blood pact.

They are wrong.

The ritual backfires catastrophically. Instead of strengthening the seal, it cracks it. A surge of raw magical energy erupts from the earth beneath Salem. Every practitioner in the chamber is either killed or transformed. The crack in the seal releases something: not the entity itself, but a pulse of its dreaming consciousness. Every magic user in Salem feels it. Every card in existence flickers. The awakened powers—the four Tier 3 signature cards—manifest for the first time.

A young cooper's apprentice, working late in a shop near the meeting house, sees the light erupt from the ground. This apprentice—later known only as The Witness—writes the first entry in what will become a journal spanning ten years and forty seasons of war:

"I saw the earth open tonight. Not a crack in the ground, but a crack in what I thought was real. The light that came out was not fire. It was older than fire. It looked at me. I think it looked at everyone. And I think it was asking a question I don't know how to answer."

The Puritan authorities blame the coven. Arrests begin. But the magic is already spreading. The crack in the seal awakened dormant powers in dozens of people across Salem—people who didn't know they had magic, people who had hidden it, people who had inherited it from ancestors burned at the stake. Within days, the factions form. Within weeks, the first battles are fought. Within a season, Salem is burning.

And watching from the shadows, a figure in a dark cloak observes everything. A silver clasp at their throat catches the firelight. The Jailer has been waiting for this moment for three hundred years.

The Factions

Dark Magic / Warlock The oldest coven in the colonies, led by Mother Corvus. They practice curses, drain, sacrifice, and corruption. They were performing the ritual that triggered the Spark—but were they trying to save the seal, or were they manipulated into breaking it?

Mother Corvus knows more than she reveals. Her secret agenda involves forcing a confrontation between the entity and the surface world. She believes magic has hidden in shame for too long.

Elemental Magic Nature-bound practitioners who draw power from fire, frost, storm, and root. They are split between those who want to preserve the natural order and those who believe the entity's awakening is a natural cycle that should not be interfered with. Their leader, a woman known only as the Storm-Caller, speaks with the voice of approaching weather.

Spellbook Magic Archivists and name-keepers. They hold the secret histories—the true names of powers older than Salem, older than the colonies, older than the Puritans' god. Their leader is the Librarian of Candle Names, a figure so old that their original name has been forgotten. They know what the entity is. They have always known. They will not say.

Oathbound Magic A knightly order bound by magical vows. Their oaths are centuries old, sworn to protect the innocent from supernatural harm. But the oaths are breaking. Some Oathbound seek freedom from their bindings. Others want to enforce them more strictly than ever. Their leader, the Silver Vow-Keeper, has not spoken in seven years—their voice bound by an oath they cannot break without dying.

Salem Folk Ordinary people. Coopers, blacksmiths, farmers, tavern-keepers. They have no magic. What they have is tools, rage, and the determination to survive in a world that has suddenly become incomprehensible. They are led by no one and everyone—their strength is in numbers and desperation. The Witness comes from their ranks.

Church Figures Not all are villains. Some genuinely protect the innocent from dark forces. Others hunt magic-users with zealot's fire. An internal schism is brewing between the merciful and the merciless. The leader of the orthodox faction, Deacon Stone, believes all magic is sin and must be purged. The leader of the reformist faction, Sister Mercy, believes magic can be redeemed and used for good.

The Awakened Ones

The four Tier 3 signature cards are not just powerful game pieces. They are living lore—entities with their own histories and agendas.

Ashen Covenant (Dark Magic) A pact forged in the first witch-burning. Not a person—a living agreement between the condemned and the fire itself. It exists as a charred document that can never be fully consumed. The names of every witch ever burned are written on it in violet flame. When it awakens into ****Black Ash****, it becomes a sentient storm of charred covenant-scrap that remembers every name and seeks vengeance for each one.

Stormglass Writ (Elemental Magic) A prophecy captured in lightning-struck glass. When lightning hit the Salem meeting house steeple, the sand beneath fused into a pane of glass containing a frozen bolt—and within the bolt, words. The prophecy shows many futures. All of them are at war. When it awakens into ****Sky Stands****, it becomes a living storm cell that hovers above the battlefield, casting lightning-judgment on all below.

Book of Candle Names (Spellbook Magic) A tome that records the true names of every being—living, dead, and some that are neither. Reading a name aloud grants power over that being. The book is bound in wax, not leather, and its pages are vellum made from pressed candle smoke. No one knows who writes the names. New ones appear while the book is closed. When it awakens into ****Names Burn****, every name written in it becomes a floating sigil of candle-flame orbiting the battlefield.

Silver Oath of Dawn (Oathbound Magic) The first vow ever sworn. An empty silver gauntlet that stands by its own will. It is the embodiment of every promise ever kept and every oath ever honored. Breaking it would unmake the concept of promises. When it awakens into ****Table Swears****, the vow becomes a binding across the entire battlefield—every promise kept strengthens allies, and every oath broken weakens enemies.

The Big Mystery

Why does magic exist in this world? What is the veil? Who or what benefits from the war continuing indefinitely?

The answer sleeps beneath America.

The entity is not a monster. It is not a god. It is a being of such vast scale and slow consciousness that its dreams take centuries to complete. The seals were not a cage built by humans to imprison it. The seals were a bargain—an agreement made thousands of years ago between the entity and the first peoples of this land. The entity chose to sleep. The seals were the terms of that sleep.

But something changed. Someone began breaking the seals. And that someone—the Jailer—is not the villain of this story. The Jailer was the first explorer to discover the entity, centuries ago. Their life was bound to the seals in exchange for forbidden knowledge. For three hundred years, they maintained the seals. But now they are breaking them, one by one, working westward.

Why? The answer comes slowly across forty seasons. The Jailer has learned something about the entity's sleep—something that changes everything. The entity is not supposed to sleep forever. It is supposed to wake. And if it doesn't wake naturally, it will die. And if it dies, something far worse will take its place beneath the continent.

The war is not about winning. It is about choosing what kind of world the entity wakes into.

The Witness

An ordinary Salem Folk who saw the Spark happen. A cooper's apprentice, age 22 when the story begins. They were working late, repairing a barrel, when the earth cracked open behind the meeting house and light poured out.

The Witness is not a fighter. They are not a leader. They are an observer—someone who writes everything down in a leather-bound journal that never leaves their side. Across forty seasons, their journal entries narrate every cutscene, every major battle, every revelation.

And across those seasons, the Witness changes.

Season 1: Young, terrified, but unable to look away. Their journal is a survival mechanism—"If I write it down, I can believe it happened."

Season 3: The Witness touches the waters of Lake Erie and has a vision of the full entity beneath the continent. They begin to show magical sensitivity.

Season 5: Now in their late 20s, the Witness has seen too much to be innocent. Their journal entries grow sharper, more analytical. They begin to piece together the Jailer's true motives.

Season 6: The Witness dies. Killed during a battle in the Delta. And then—three days later—they return. Changed. Their skin is slightly translucent at the temples, revealing a faint blue-white glow beneath. They are now something between human and entity-touched. The entity speaks through them for the first time, in a voice that sounds like continents shifting: "Remember."

Season 9: The Witness, now a middle-aged veteran of a decade-long war, has become a faction leader in their own right. They lead not with power but with knowledge—they have seen more of the entity than anyone alive.

Season 10: The Witness names the entity. Naming gives it form, and form gives it limits. This is the final choice of the war—not a battle, but a naming. And the Witness, who started as a terrified apprentice with a journal, is the only one who can do it.

SEASON 1: SALEM ARCANA

Detailed Narrative

ACT 1: THE SPARK IGNITES

Opening Cutscene: The Spark Event Duration: 90 seconds. The Witness narrates throughout.

It is winter in Salem, 1692. Snow on the rooftops. Lanterns swinging in the wind. The meeting house stands dark and silent—but beneath it, in a chamber carved from the earth, a coven works in secret. Mother Corvus leads the ritual, her silver athame raised. Around her, Dark Magic practitioners chant in a language older than English, older than Latin. They are trying to strengthen the seal. They believe they are saving the world.

The ritual circle is drawn in ash and blood. Candles burn at seven points. The air is thick with incense and anticipation.

The Witness, a young cooper's apprentice, is working late three streets away. They hear nothing. See nothing. But they feel something—a pressure change, like before a storm. They look up from their work.

In the chamber, the ritual reaches its climax. Mother Corvus speaks the final word.

And the seal cracks.

Not a physical crack. A crack in reality itself. Violet light erupts from the center of the ritual circle. The candles extinguish simultaneously. The ash and blood ignite. The practitioners are thrown backward. Three of them are killed instantly. Two are transformed—their bodies becoming conduits for the escaping energy, their eyes burning with violet fire.

Mother Corvus alone remains standing. She has seen this coming. This was not the ritual's intended outcome—but it was one she had prepared for. As the light pours out of the earth, she smiles.

Above ground, the Witness sees the light. It erupts from behind the meeting house like a second sunrise—but violet, not gold. The light pulses once, twice, three times. And on the third pulse, every magic user in Salem feels it. Cards flicker in collections across the town. The four Tier 3 signatures manifest in the hands of their destined bearers. The war has begun.

The Witness opens their journal. Charcoal stick trembling, they write the first words: "I saw the earth open tonight..."

Faction Introduction Montage Six short vignettes, 15-20 seconds each.

Dark Magic: Mother Corvus stands in the wreckage of the ritual chamber. Her coven lies dead or transformed around her. She reaches into the violet light still pulsing from the crack and pulls out a charred document—the Ashen Covenant. It burns in her hand but does not consume. "The pact is renewed," she whispers. "The first name was hers. The last name will be mine."

Elemental: The Storm-Caller stands alone on a hill outside Salem. As the violet pulse washes over her, she raises her arms to the sky. The clouds above her begin to rotate. Lightning strikes the ground at her feet, and where it strikes, the Stormglass Writ forms—a pane of glass with a bolt frozen inside. She touches it. Her eyes go white. "I have seen the futures," she says to no one. "All of them. We must choose carefully."

Spellbook: In the hidden library beneath a candle-maker's shop, the Librarian of Candle Names feels the pulse. The Book of Candle Names, which has been silent for a century, opens itself. A new name writes itself on a blank page. The Librarian reads it aloud—and somewhere in Salem, the person whose name was written feels a shiver. "The names are waking up," the Librarian murmurs. "And they are hungry to be spoken."

Oathbound: The Silver Vow-Keeper kneels in a chapel. They have not spoken in seven years—an oath of silence binds them. When the pulse hits, the Silver Oath of Dawn appears before them: an empty gauntlet, standing upright by its own will. The Vow-Keeper reaches out and touches it. For the first time in seven years, they speak: "The oldest oath is breaking. I felt it." Around them, other Oathbound gasp. The Vow-Keeper's voice is the sound of something ending.

Salem Folk: A tavern. Ordinary people drinking, laughing, arguing. The pulse hits. The lanterns flicker. The laughter stops. Someone screams. Someone else grabs a knife—not because they know what's happening, but because they know something is happening, and in Salem, when something happens, it usually ends with someone burning. The Witness is among them, journal clutched to their chest. They are the only one writing. The only one watching.

Church Figures: Deacon Stone stands in the pulpit of the Salem meeting house. When the pulse hits, he grips the lectern until his knuckles go white. His eyes narrow. "Witchcraft," he hisses. "I knew it. I have always known it." In the back of the church, Sister Mercy crosses herself. She feels the pulse differently—as pain, as grief. She knows that innocent people are about to die.

The Player's Choice

The player—a new practitioner whose powers awakened with the Spark—is approached by representatives of all four magical factions. Each offers a Tier 3 signature card and an invitation to join their cause. The player must choose one. This is not just a strategic choice. It is a narrative binding. The card chooses the player as much as the player chooses the card.

This moment is presented as a cutscene where the four signature cards appear before the player: the Ashen Covenant burning but not consuming, the Stormglass Writ crackling with frozen lightning, the Book of Candle Names writing a new name as they watch, the Silver Oath of Dawn standing silent and waiting.

Early Conflict

The Puritan authorities begin rounding up suspected witches. Not the real magic users—they've gone to ground. The ones they arrest are ordinary people: the healer who knows herbs, the old woman who talks to her cats, the midwife who has delivered too many healthy babies to be natural.

Salem Folk riot. They know the accused are innocent. They storm the meeting house. Deacon Stone orders the militia to fire on the crowd. The first blood of the war is not magical. It is ordinary people killed by ordinary bullets.

The magical factions emerge from hiding. They do not do so to save the Salem Folk—at least, not at first. They emerge because the crack in the seal is growing, and if it is not controlled, it will consume Salem entirely.

Sister Mercy breaks from Deacon Stone's authority. She leads a group of reformist Church Figures to the crack, attempting to heal it with prayer and sacred rituals. It doesn't work—but it slows the crack's growth. For the first time, Church Figures and magic-users fight on the same side.

Act 1 Twist

The Spark was not an accident. Someone triggered it deliberately.

A shadowy figure is glimpsed leaving the scene of the ritual chamber in the chaos after the pulse. Tall, cloaked, hooded. No face is visible. But a silver clasp at the throat catches the firelight. The Jailer has been here all along.

The Witness sees the figure and writes: "There was someone watching. Not fleeing—watching. Like they had been waiting for this to happen. Like they had made it happen."

ACT 2: SECRETS AND ALLIANCES

The Awakening System Discovered

As battles intensify, the player learns of the awakening system. Their Tier 3 card begins to "speak" to them—not in words, but in impulses, in dreams, in the way the card art seems to shift when no one is looking. The card wants to awaken. It needs three specific passive-hook cards, positioned in the three lane groups. The player begins hunting for these cards.

Temporary Alliances

The six factions form and break alliances with dizzying speed. Dark Magic and Elemental Magic briefly ally against the Church Figures—but the alliance shatters when Mother Corvus tries to sacrifice an Elemental practitioner to fuel a spell. The Oathbound pledge to protect the Salem Folk—but the Salem Folk don't trust anyone with magic, even those sworn to protect them. The reformist Church Figures under Sister Mercy find common ground with the Spellbook archivists, who share knowledge of the seals.

The First Awakening

In a pivotal battle, a rival achieves the first awakening. It is not the player. It is someone else—an enemy, an ally, it doesn't matter. What matters is that the world changes when it happens.

The rival's Tier 3 card rises from its slot. The three passive-hook cards pulse. The card transforms—the art style shifts from static to luminous, the painted elements become real, the awakened being steps partially out of the frame. The infusion trails ignite. Every player on both sides feels it.

The Witness writes: "I have seen lightning strike a tree. I have seen a house catch fire in a storm. Neither compares. The air tasted like copper and old parchment. The hair on my arms stood up. Every candle in the room guttered at once. And for one moment—one heartbeat—I felt something beneath the floorboards. Something vast. Something that had been sleeping. The awakening had not created power. It had borrowed it. From something that noticed us for the first time."

The player now knows it can be done. They chase their own awakening recipe.

The Betrayal

A faction leader is revealed to be working with the shadowy figure. The traitor is not Mother Corvus—she is too obvious a suspect. The traitor is one of the Oathbound's lieutenants, the Keeper of the Second Vow. They have been feeding information to the Jailer in exchange for promises that their broken oaths can be forgiven.

When exposed, the Keeper does not deny it. "The oaths are chains," they say. "The Jailer offered me a key. You would have taken it too."

The Jailer appears briefly during the confrontation—a silhouette in a doorway, the silver clasp glinting. They speak for the first time. Their voice is old, tired, and carries an accent that no one can place. "The seals are breaking," they say. "Not because I want them to. Because they must. You do not understand yet. But you will."

Then they are gone.

The Witness writes: "Trust was our first casualty. The Keeper of the Second Vow—someone we all respected—has been speaking to the shadow. To the one who watches. They said the seals **MUST** break. They said we would understand. I am afraid of understanding."

ACT 3: THE FIRST BATTLE OF SALEM

The Convergence

All six factions converge on Salem for a climactic battle. The crack in the seal has grown to a visible fissure in the earth, running from the meeting house to the harbor. Violet light pulses from it like a heartbeat. The entity beneath is stirring.

The battle is chaos. No clear sides. Every faction fights every other faction, with temporary alliances forming and breaking in the space of single turns. The player fights through the chaos, pursuing their awakening.

The Player's Awakening

In the heat of the battle, the player achieves their awakening. The three passive-hook cards lock into place. The Tier 3 anchor rises. The transformation begins.

This is the player's moment. The cutscene mirrors the earlier first awakening but from the player's perspective. Their card awakens. The infusion trails ignite. The battle shifts.

The Jailer's Partial Reveal

In the aftermath of the player's awakening, the Jailer appears openly for the first time. They walk through the battlefield untouched—not because they are invulnerable, but because everyone is too exhausted, too shocked, to stop them.

The Jailer approaches the crack in the seal. They kneel. They place a hand on the fissure. And for a moment, the violet light dims. The heartbeat slows.

"You are not ready," the Jailer says to the gathered factions. "But you will need to be. This is only the first seal. The first town. There are seals beneath every river, every mountain, every territory between here and the other coast. By the time you reach the last one, you will understand what I am doing. Or you will be dead."

They stand. The hood has fallen back slightly, revealing part of a weathered face—old, but not ancient. Human, but not entirely. The silver clasp at their throat catches the firelight.

"My name was taken from me long ago," they say. "But you may call me the Jailer. I have been maintaining these seals for three hundred years. Now I am breaking them. Ask yourselves why a jailer would break the locks they spent centuries protecting."

They turn and walk into the smoke. No one follows.

Season 1 Closing

Salem is devastated but not destroyed. The crack in the seal has stabilized—not healed, but no longer growing. The factions have seen what they are fighting over. They have seen an awakening. They have seen the Jailer. They know the war is bigger than Salem.

The Witness writes the final journal entry of Season 1, their charcoal stick worn to a nub:

"This was only the first town. The fire will cross every river, every mountain, every territory between here and the other coast. We are not fighting for Salem anymore. We are fighting for what America becomes. I am twenty-two years old. I do not know if I will live to see the end of this. But I will write everything down. Someone should remember."

Stinger

A map of the American colonies. A burning line traces westward from Salem, across Massachusetts, toward the Hudson River. The line is violet fire.

Text appears: "Season 2: The Hudson Veil"

In the shadows at the edge of the map, a dark figure watches. A silver clasp glints.

SEASON 2: THE HUDSON VEIL

Detailed Narrative

ACT 1: THE RIVER BECKONS

Opening Cutscene: The Exodus The Witness narrates.

Fall 1693. The factions flee Salem. The town is uninhabitable—the crack in the seal pulses with violet light, and the entity's dreams are seeping through. People who sleep too close to the fissure wake up speaking languages that don't exist, drawing maps of places they've never seen, writing names that aren't theirs.

The exodus moves west, toward the Hudson River—the first major barrier between Salem and the rest of the continent. The column of refugees is a strange sight: Dark Magic practitioners in black cloaks walking alongside Salem Folk farmers with pitchforks on their shoulders. Elemental adepts who make the wind favorable for travel. Oathbound knights guarding the flanks. Church Figures split into two groups—Deacon Stone's zealots, who want to turn back and burn Salem to ash, and Sister Mercy's reformers, who walk among the refugees offering what comfort they can.

The Witness walks among them, journal in hand, writing constantly. They are now 23. The scar on their left eyebrow has been joined by a new one on their jaw—a cut from flying glass during the Battle of Salem.

New Geography

The Hudson River Valley is contested territory. French trappers, British colonists, and Native nations—the Mohican, the Munsee, the Haudenosaunee—all have claims here. The factions cannot simply march through. They must negotiate passage, and not everyone is willing.

More importantly: the river itself is magical. It is a "veil"—one of the seals that keeps the entity dormant. Crossing it will have consequences.

The New Tier 3 Signatures Manifest

Two new Tier 3 cards appear in the world, drawn to the energy of the Hudson Veil.

Skybound Totem rises from an ancient burial mound on the river's eastern bank. It is a totem carved from lightning-struck cedar, older than the colonies, older than the tribes that currently live here. It was placed here by a civilization that predates history, one of the original peoples who made the bargain with the entity. When the factions approach, the totem awakens and calls a storm. The Storm-Caller of the Elemental faction must prove herself worthy to claim it. She does—by standing in the center of the storm and letting lightning strike her three times. On the third strike, the totem recognizes her and the storm ceases.

Mirror-Sigil coalesces from the displaced magic of European refugees—not a Native artifact, but something new. The accumulated magical residue of every European practitioner who crossed the Atlantic, concentrated by the Hudson Veil's energy, condenses into a single reflective sigil. It belongs to no faction. It appears to whoever needs it most. It appears to a young Spellbook apprentice who lost their master in the Battle of Salem and has been carrying the master's unfinished grimoire ever since. The Mirror-Sigil bonds with the grimoire, and the apprentice becomes something new: a bearer of a Tier 3 card, with all the power and danger that entails.

The Jailer Watches

The Jailer is present throughout Act 1, always at a distance. They are seen on hilltops, at the edges of forests, standing on the far bank of streams the factions are about to cross. They never interfere. They only watch.

The Witness notices that the Jailer seems to be waiting for something specific. "They are not following us," the Witness writes. "They are ahead of us. They reached the Hudson before we did. They are waiting for us to catch up."

ACT 2: THE VEIL THINS

Crossing Rituals

Each faction pursues a different method of crossing the Hudson. The Dark Magic coven attempts to force passage by draining the river's magical energy—a ritual that would weaken the veil but allow them to cross safely. The Elemental practitioners seek to appease the river's spirit, offering gifts of fire and frost. The Spellbook archivists research ancient crossing rituals in texts that predate European contact. The Oathbound simply build boats and trust to their vows. The Salem Folk follow whoever seems most likely to get them across alive. The Church Figures are split: Deacon Stone wants to dam the river and

march across, Sister Mercy wants to bless it.

None of these methods work cleanly. The river resists. It is a seal, and seals do not want to be crossed.

Tensions with Native Practitioners

The indigenous peoples of the Hudson Valley are not passive observers. They have known about the seal for thousands of years. They know what crossing it will mean. Some are hostile—they do not want the war brought to their lands. Some are willing to negotiate. Some offer guidance, for a price.

A Mohican elder, known only as the River-Knower, agrees to speak with the faction leaders. She is ancient—ninety years old, blind, carried to the meeting on a litter. But her sight is not in her eyes. She "sees" the magical currents of the river the way others see sunlight.

"You are about to do something that cannot be undone," she tells the assembled leaders. "The Hudson Veil is one of seven major seals stretching from the salt water to the sweet water. Each seal you cross weakens the thing beneath. My people made a bargain with that thing when your ancestors were still building boats to cross the ocean. We agreed to let it sleep. We agreed to guard the seals. That bargain kept this land stable for ten thousand years. You have undone a thousand years of stability in a single season."

Mother Corvus asks what will happen if all seven seals break.

The River-Knower is silent for a long moment. Then: "It will wake. And it will remember who broke the seals and who tried to protect them. I hope, for your sake, that you are on the right side of that accounting."

Midpoint Revelation

The Hudson Veil is not just a seal. It is one of several. Seven major seals stretch across the continent, from the Atlantic to the Pacific. Each one is tied to a major geographical feature: river, lake, mountain range, desert, forest, coastline. Breaking the seals weakens the entity's sleep. Breaking all of them will wake it.

The Jailer appears to the player during a quiet moment. It is the first time they speak directly, one-on-one.

"You are wondering why I am doing this," the Jailer says. "You have heard the River-Knower's warning. You think I am a villain."

The player can respond—accuse, question, or stay silent.

"The seals were a bargain," the Jailer continues, "but bargains have terms. The entity agreed to sleep for ten thousand years. That time is almost up. If it does not wake naturally, it will die. And if it dies, the space it occupies beneath this continent—the void where it dreams—will not stay empty. Something else will fill it. Something that never made any bargains. Something that does not sleep."

They lean closer. The silver clasp at their throat catches the moonlight.

"I am not breaking the seals to destroy the world. I am breaking them to give the world a chance. The entity must wake on its own terms, not be forced awake by its death. And for that, it needs the seals broken in the right order, at the right time, by the right hands. I have been arranging those hands for three hundred years. Including yours."

They step back into shadow.

"You will hate me before this is over. That is acceptable. What matters is that you reach the final seal before I do. Because when you get there, you will have to make a choice. And I want to make sure you are prepared to make it."

ACT 3: THE CROSSING

The Battle at the Hudson

The crossing does not go peacefully. Deacon Stone, impatient with negotiation, launches an assault on the river's magical defenses, attempting to force passage. His attack triggers a response from the seal itself—the river rises, animated by ancient protective magic, and attacks everyone on both banks.

The factions are forced to fight the river itself while simultaneously fighting each other. It is chaos. Boats capsize. People drown. Magic crackles across the water in wild, uncontrolled bursts.

A Faction Leader Dies

Deacon Stone, in a moment of zealous fury, attempts to smite the river with a holy relic—a piece of the True Cross, or so he believes. The relic shatters against the seal's defenses. The backlash kills him instantly.

His death sends shockwaves through the Church Figures. Sister Mercy, who has opposed him for two seasons, kneels beside his body. She closes his eyes. She says a prayer. And then she stands up and takes command of the faction.

"We have been fighting the wrong war," she announces. "Not against magic. Not against the river. Against our own fear. Deacon Stone was a good man who let fear make him cruel. I will not make that mistake."

The Fragment Escapes

The combined magical energy of the battle—the factions' spells, Deacon Stone's shattered relic, the river's own defenses—creates a catastrophic surge. The Hudson Veil cracks. Not breaks entirely—but cracks.

From the crack, a fragment of the entity's dreaming consciousness escapes. It is not the entity itself. It is a splinter—a piece of a dream given form. It looks like a mass of roiling shadow with occasional suggestions of features: an eye that forms and dissolves, a mouth that opens and closes, hands that reach out and pull back.

The fragment screams—a sound that is heard not with ears but with minds—and flies westward, following the line of the seals toward the Great Lakes.

The Jailer watches it go. For the first time, their expression is not calm. They look frustrated. Even afraid.

"That was not supposed to happen," they mutter. "Not yet. Not here."

The Jailer's True Goal

In the aftermath, the Jailer speaks openly to the assembled factions for the first time. They stand on the western bank of the Hudson, the river now calm behind them, the fragment's distant scream echoing in everyone's minds.

"You have seen what escapes when a seal is broken carelessly," they say. "Imagine that, but a thousand times larger. Imagine the entity's full consciousness, fragmented, scattered across the continent, each piece mad with the pain of a death that should not have happened. That is what will occur if the entity dies in its sleep. That is what I am trying to prevent."

They point westward.

"There are six more major seals between here and the far ocean. The fragment that escaped tonight will reach the next seal before you do. It will try to break it. You must reach each seal before the fragment does—or before someone else breaks it recklessly. You must break the seals carefully, in the right order, with the right rituals. And at the final seal, you must be prepared to make a choice that I cannot make for you."

Mother Corvus asks what choice.

"The entity will wake. That is inevitable now—the seals are too damaged, the process too far along. When it wakes, it will be disoriented. Frightened. A being of that scale, afraid, could destroy the continent by accident. Or it could be calmed. Named. Given form instead of formlessness. Someone will have to name it. And that someone must understand what it is—not a monster, not a god, but a living continent, a creature so old it remembers when the land was underwater. Are any of you prepared to name such a thing?"

No one answers.

"I thought not," the Jailer says. "Then you have work to do."

Season 2 Closing

The factions stand on the western bank of the Hudson. They have crossed the first major seal. They have seen a fragment of the entity escape. They have lost a faction leader. They have heard the Jailer's explanation—and none of them fully trusts it.

The Witness writes:

"The river is behind us. Whatever came out of it is ahead of us. The Jailer says they are trying to save the world. I want to believe them. But I also saw their face when the fragment escaped. They were afraid. Not of the fragment. Of something else. Something they are not telling us. I am beginning to understand: this is not a war. This is a prison break. And I am not sure whether we are freeing the prisoner or becoming its next cell."

Stinger

The map zooms out. The burning line traces from Salem to the Hudson, then continues westward. It reaches the Great Lakes—five vast bodies of water glittering like inland seas. The fragment's trajectory arcs toward the lakes.

Text appears: "Season 3: The Iron Lakes"

Beneath the map, the entity stirs in its sleep. For the first time, it makes a sound. Not a word. Not a scream. A hum. A vibration that travels up through the earth and into the bones of everyone standing on the western bank.

The Witness looks down at their journal. The charcoal stick in their hand is vibrating.

They keep writing.

SEASON 3: THE IRON LAKES (Summary)

Region: Great Lakes New Tier 3 Cards: None (first Tier 3 cards are on Season 1 and 2 anchors) Key Events:

The escaped fragment reaches the Great Lakes before the factions do. It begins corrupting the region—animals mutate, weather patterns go mad, ships disappear on calm waters. The lakes are rich in iron, and the iron resonates with the fragment's energy, creating "iron storms" where the water itself becomes briefly magnetic.

The factions arrive scattered. Some come by land. Some build or commandeer ships. Lake battles become a new form of warfare—ships firing not cannonballs but spells, boarding actions where cards are played on swaying decks.

A faction schism occurs. The Oathbound split into two sub-factions: those who want to hunt the fragment and destroy it, led by the newly vocal Silver Vow-Keeper, and those who want to let it lead them to the next seal, believing the Jailer's explanation. The split is bitter and produces its own civil war within the larger war.

The Witness touches the water of Lake Erie and has a vision. They see the full entity beneath the continent—a vast network of glowing veins stretching from the Atlantic to lands they can't name. The entity speaks for the first time. One word: "Remember."

The climactic battle occurs on Lake Michigan. The fragment tries to possess a lake spirit—a luminous being of water and light. The factions, the Jailer, and the lake spirit itself fight the fragment in a four-way battle. The fragment is re-contained, bound

into an iron cage. But the lake spirit is destroyed in the process, and the region is scarred.

After the battle, the Jailer gives their confession. They were once human—the first European explorer to discover the entity, three hundred years ago. In exchange for the knowledge of the seals, their life was bound to them. They have been alive, unchanging, for three centuries. Maintaining the seals. Waiting. And now, breaking them.

The season closes with the Witness's journal entry: "I saw it. The thing beneath. It stretches from the Atlantic to lands we haven't named yet. It is not evil. It is not good. It simply IS. And it is waking up."

Stinger: The map zooms to the Mississippi River. Season 4: "The Heartland Rift."

SEASON 4: THE HEARTLAND RIFT (Summary)

Region: Mississippi River Valley Key Events:

The Mississippi River is a major seal—the entity's "heart" is somewhere beneath it. The river is vast, muddy, and alive with its own magic. Riverboat battles replace lake battles. Agricultural magic emerges—practitioners who draw power from the rich soil of the floodplain, from the cycle of planting and harvest, from the deep time of the river.

The Witness gains their first active magical ability. The entity-touch from their Lake Erie vision has left a mark. They can now "feel" the seals—sense when one is nearby and how close it is to breaking. This ability makes them invaluable to the factions, and also makes them a target. Everyone wants the Witness on their side.

The Jailer appears more frequently now, sometimes fighting alongside the factions, sometimes working against them. Their motives remain ambiguous. They save lives and cause deaths with equal calm. The Witness begins keeping a separate section of their journal dedicated to the Jailer's actions, trying to discern a pattern.

SEASON 5: SMOKE OVER APPALACHIA (Summary)

Region: Appalachian Mountains New Tier 3 Card: Soul-Flame Pact (Dark Magic) Key Events:

The war reaches the mountains. The Appalachians are old—older than the entity, older than the seals. Magic here is different: coal and smoke spirits, isolationist covens that have hidden in the hollows for generations, practitioners who speak with the bones of the mountains.

The Jailer's full backstory is revealed in flashbacks. Three hundred years ago, they were an explorer—a cartographer sent to map the interior of the continent. They discovered the first seal by accident and, in their curiosity, broke it slightly. The entity spoke to them. Offered them a bargain: knowledge in exchange for service. The Jailer accepted. For three centuries, they have maintained the seals. But now the bargain is ending. The ten thousand years of sleep are almost over. The entity must wake, or die.

A faction reunification begins. The Oathbound schism, started in Season 3, begins to heal. The Vow-Keeper and the rebel leader meet in secret and forge a new oath—one that acknowledges both the need to hunt fragments and the need to prepare for the entity's waking.

SEASON 6: DELTA SUNDERING (Summary)

Region: Bayou and Gulf Coast Key Events:

The war reaches the southern territories—bayous, deltas, and the Gulf Coast. Swamp magic dominates: death and rebirth cycles, voodoo influences, practitioners who do not fear death because they have learned that in the swamp, nothing truly dies.

The Witness dies. Killed during a battle in the bayou—a stray spell, a random moment of chaos. They are dead for three days. The factions mourn. The Jailer, uncharacteristically, is visibly shaken.

And then the Witness returns. Not resurrected—transformed. Their skin is slightly translucent at the temples, revealing a faint blue-white glow beneath. They are now something between human and entity-touched. The entity speaks through them for the first time, in a voice that sounds like continents shifting: "Remember."

The Witness's journal entries after their return are different. More poetic. More certain. They have seen something during those three days—been somewhere, spoken with something. They will not say what. But their guidance becomes more direct, more confident. They are no longer just an observer. They are a participant.

SEASON 7: THE LONE STAR CONVERGENCE (Summary)

Region: Texas and Southwest New Tier 3 Card: Codex of Echoing Names (Spellbook) Key Events:

The war reaches the Southwest—desert magic, mission churches, Comanche spiritual traditions. Multiple factions converge on the region simultaneously, creating a mega-alliance against the Jailer, who has become increasingly aggressive in breaking seals.

The revelation: the entity chose to sleep. The seals were a bargain, not a cage. The first peoples of the continent did not imprison the entity—they made an agreement with it. The entity wanted to sleep, to dream, to gestate something that would take ten thousand years to form. It asked the first peoples to guard its sleep. They agreed, in exchange for the land's fertility and protection from the things that live beyond the veil. This changes everything. The Jailer is not freeing a prisoner. They are waking a volunteer. And the question becomes: what will the entity be like when it wakes? Ten thousand years of dreams could produce anything—wisdom, madness, or both.

SEASON 8: ROCKY MOUNTAIN SCHISM (Summary)

Region: Rocky Mountains Key Events:

The war reaches the high country. High-altitude magic, isolation and transcendence, gold rush occultism. The mountains are the spine of the continent, and the seals here are different—more ancient, more powerful, less willing to be broken.

The Jailer faces their final choice: help complete the awakening, or prevent it. Three hundred years of service have brought them to this point. They have spent the last eight seasons breaking seals. But now, at the highest point of the continent, they hesitate.

They reveal to the player and the Witness: "I am tired. I have been tired for two hundred years. I want to rest. But if I stop now, the entity dies. And I do not know which is worse—its death or its waking. I have been hoping you would figure it out for me."

The factions must also choose. Continue breaking seals, hoping the entity wakes benevolent? Or try to reinforce the remaining seals, risking the entity's death and the void that would follow?

SEASON 9: THE GOLDEN VEIL (Summary)

Region: California, West Coast Key Events:

The final seal lies at the edge of the continent. Gold rush magic, Pacific energies, the last barrier between the entity and full wakefulness. All remaining Tier 3 signatures are now in play.

The Witness, now a middle-aged veteran of a decade-long war, becomes a faction leader in their own right. They lead not with power but with knowledge—they have seen more of the entity than anyone alive. They have been touched by it. They have carried its voice in their throat. They know what it is, and what it is not.

The climax approaches: all seals broken or breaking. The entity stirs beneath the continent. Everyone can feel it now—not just magic-users, but ordinary people. The ground hums. The ocean pulls back from the shore. The sky at sunset is the wrong color.

The Pacific Veilkeepers—the guardians of the final seal—are introduced. They are the last line: an alliance of Chinese railroad workers, Hawaiian priests, Russian fur traders, and the indigenous peoples of the coast. They do not seek to win the war. They seek to ensure that when the entity rises, it rises on their terms.

SEASON 10: THE NAMING OF THE LAND (Summary)

Region: West Coast, the Final Seal Key Events:

The entity rises. Not in a single moment of apocalyptic rupture, but slowly. The ground swells. The sky bends. The ocean at the edge of the continent begins to glow. The entity is not a creature that bursts from the earth. It IS the earth. It has always been the earth. The continent is its body. The seals were the lullaby that kept it sleeping.

The final confrontation is not a battle. It is a choice, presented to the player and to the Witness. The entity is awake. It is disoriented. Its dreams—ten thousand years of accumulated imagery, memory, emotion—are spilling into the physical world. If it is not given form, it will remain formless, and its formlessness will reshape the continent in chaotic, unpredictable ways.

Someone must name it. Naming gives form, and form gives limits. The Witness, who started as a terrified apprentice with a journal, is the only one who can do it. They know the entity. They have carried its voice. They have died and returned with its

light behind their eyes.

The player's choices across all ten seasons—which faction they supported, which seals they helped break or protect, how they treated the Jailer—determine the endings.

Ending 1: The Benevolent Awakening. The Witness names the entity with understanding and compassion. The entity wakes fully, takes a recognizable form (a vast humanoid figure of living earth and light), and speaks. It thanks the factions for guiding its waking. It offers to continue the bargain: protection and fertility in exchange for respecting its rest-wake cycles. A new era begins.

Ending 2: The Wrathful Awakening. The Witness names the entity with fear and accusation. The entity wakes angry—centuries of dreams twisted by the violence of the war, by the fragments that escaped, by the careless breaking of seals. It is not evil, but it is hurt. And a hurt continent is a dangerous thing. The factions must now manage a being of geological scale that does not trust them.

Ending 3: The Witness's Sacrifice. The Witness does not name the entity. Instead, they merge with it—offering their own consciousness as the stabilizing form. The Witness ceases to exist as an individual. They become the entity's voice. The entity wakes, and when it speaks, it speaks with the Witness's voice, uses the Witness's words, remembers everything the Witness wrote. The journal becomes the entity's first memory of the surface world.

Ending 4: The Jailer's Redemption. If the player supported the Jailer throughout, the Jailer offers their own name as the final seal. They have been bound to the seals for three centuries. They can become the final binding—not to keep the entity asleep, but to give it a stable anchor in the waking world. The Jailer merges with the final seal. The entity wakes. The Jailer is gone—but their silver clasp remains, embedded in the earth where the final seal was, catching the sunrise.

Final Image: The North American continent, seen from above. The entity's form—whatever it has become—is visible as a pattern of light beneath the land. The war is over. What comes next is not a battle. It is a relationship. The continent is alive. And it remembers.